

Das Kapital



Marx's political philosophy was based on a view of history as a series of class struggles. By the mid-19th century the antagonism was clearly between the working class 'proletariat', and their capitalist employers. Capitalism had become the predominant economic system of the industrialized world, and as part of his analysis of the contemporary class struggle Marx wrote a comprehensive critique of it, *Das Kapital*. The owners of the means of production are motivated by profit, he argued, through accumulation of capital that is produced by their workforce. Marx saw this as a fundamentally exploitative relationship, in which the workers are forced to maintain a system that oppresses them, ultimately dehumanizing and alienating them. He also acknowledged some positive aspects of capitalism, both as an improvement on feudalism, but also as a stimulus to improving means of production and economic growth.

However, he saw capitalism as just a stage in history – in dialectical terms, as a thesis containing within it an opposing antithesis that would bring about change.